

Flight of the PHOENIX

How the turbocharged ambition of a milk seller changed the aviation history of India



SIMPLY FLY: A DECCAN ODYSSEY
by CAPTAIN GOPINATH
Collins
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 366

By Dilip Bobb

If there was a statue of Captain Gopinath anywhere, thousands of Indians would be lining up to offer garlands of gratitude. It was his pioneering low-cost airline that allowed them to literally take to the skies, a luxury unaffordable for most Indians till Deccan Airways came along. He sub-titles this, his autobiography, *A Deccan Odyssey*, but the launch, phenomenal growth and birth of an iconic brand, followed by the decline and eventual sale to Vijay Mallya, is only part of the Gopinath story. This is a man who adopted many avatars before becoming part of aviation history. A better title would be "Flight of the Phoenix" for the way he reinvented himself over the years. In fact, "Captain" was his rank in the army and not, as is popularly believed, a pilot. From marginal farmer to milk seller, poultry, silk-worms, motorcycle and irrigation equipment dealer, Udupi Hotel owner, agricultural consultant and politician, apart from the army stint, Gopinath is a prime example of entrepreneurial overdrive, each avatar bringing lessons and experiences that led to the next.

Autobiographies of successful entrepreneurs offer inspirational reading but not all live up to the hype. Some are vanity publications, a literary ego massage which elevates the subject between Saint and Superman. Others are ghost-written which also produces a version that is sanitised and misleading. Those who know Gopinath, including his business rivals, will vouch for two attributes: courage of conviction and straight talk. This is his story but it is in his words, his thoughts; the failures get as much play as the successes and so do those men and women mostly

anonymous till now, who helped him take his entrepreneurial ambitions to each new level. He is no Richard Branson or even Mallya, with a glam lifestyle which attracts a certain readership. He is, instead, a man born into near poverty but one who saw opportunity where others saw despair, a classic rags to riches story but one that is hugely inspirational and yet a cautionary tale. He brings a rare honesty to the literary table which, in certain situations, makes him more victim than hero, but that is the best part of this book. This is warts-and-all Gopinath, emotional, impulsive, often irrationally so, yet audacity, belief and the gambler's instinct helped him achieve the impossible.

When he decides to launch a low-cost airline, he has Rs 6,000 to his name. Within six months of launch, he orders aircraft worth Rs 12,000 crore. Deccan had less than a crore in the bank. His story, like most successful entrepreneurs, comes with its element of luck and happenstance, but at the end, this is a case of fortune favouring the brave. He starts life as the son of a poor school teacher, is pushed by his headmaster to join Sainik School which leads to a commission in the army and then, inexplicably, gives it up to return to the family farm in a remote part of the Western Ghats.

The army taught him leadership skills, earning respect and ethics. Trying to make success of a small, barren farm brings another valuable lesson: cost-cutting. It also shows him—and us—just how much of a stumbling block to progress the bureaucracy at every level, really is. Gopinath is a doer but also a thinker. His life story is one of trial and tribulation but at every stage of his career, he analyses and examines the serious endemic flaws in the Indian system and offers solutions and alternatives. That adds considerable value to this autobiography.



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